

Hey, friends, it's Eric Malzone. And in this short audio lecture, we are going to talk about "Differentiating Your Podcast." Kind of the name of the game, right? We want to be a little bit different. We want to have something unique to offer. And we'll go through some definite strategies on that. But really the ultimate differentiator is you. No one is like you. You are a unique snowflake, right? And we're all different. We all have different lives we've lived and perspectives and experiences. So just always remember that. That you are core to differentiate your podcast just by being who you are.

Now, there's a lot of podcasts out there, but that doesn't mean you can't differentiate quickly. So ways to do that are really finding a solid niche and maybe going deeper into that niche. You know, I've talked about throughout this course maybe even just doing something that's hyper-local to your local city or zip code or town or geography, things that are considered "edutainment," as the kids say nowadays-- a mixture of education and entertainment. People like to be spoon-fed their information in a very fun and engaging way.

A creativity-- there's so much room for creativity in this medium, it's awesome. And just looking at other original formats, I mean, you think about *The Joe Rogan Experience*. Yeah, it's been around for a while. It's the number-one podcast in the world and has been for years. But when he first started, he helped create the whole long-form podcast category of just two-, three-hour interviews, sometimes more, up to four hours. It's ridiculous, right? Who would have thought that people would have sat and listened to a three-hour podcast? Well, proven out, a lot of people.

*Hot Ones*-- which was one of my favorites-- the YouTube series where they have guests on, very, very famous people, and they make them eat increasingly hot, hot sauces on each chicken wing as they answer a different question. It's really funny, and he's an excellent interviewer. So *Crime Junkie*, one of the original of the storytelling true crime series. *Ear Hustle* which is stories from people inside jail. There's a lot of different original formats. And I know that these aren't unique to fitness, health, and wellness, but always be looking outside of our vertical for interesting ideas that you can bring in.

And always make sure that you're staying true to your mission and vision, your core values of what the podcast is. And you'll work on this throughout the course. But it's really easy to get distracted. I can tell you from personal experience. You see something shiny. You want to go and maybe do that interview or cover this topic, but maybe it's not really what your audience is expecting and may be a turnoff for them. So keep the guardrails tight, stay disciplined. I do it all the time.

But on the flip side- and I know this is contradictory to what I just said-- it is your podcast. So explore the fringes of what you want to do. That's the nice thing about it. And no one's telling you what to do on this show. You can create what you want. But just know how it'll resonate with your audience. Yeah, and then your unique selling proposition. So what is the unique offering that you have for an audience, right? What is something that they want that you are promising to give them? And that's really a consistent theme of your podcast.

And I'll give you some examples. So *Future of Fitness*-- my podcast-- I've always said from the day one, I want to help the industry skate to where the puck is going. What's coming around the corner? What's new and innovative? How do we stay up to date? *Mind Pump*-- which is one of my favorite podcasts-- bringing truth to the health and fitness worldwide. That's their USP. *The Rich Roll Podcast*-- an excellent one as well-- unlock your best self. So what is your promise? What is your unique selling proposition? Sorry. That's hard to say sometimes.

But I really encourage you to do some self-reflection on that. What is it that you want to bring to your audience that is of value to them? That may be analyzing other podcasts or, quote-unquote, competitors and identifying gaps in the market. And how can you take concepts that have worked in other niches, other content types, and adapt them to what you do? Creative content and format strategies. So content differentiation, offering unique and valuable content is kind of in the name of the game, right?

And we talked about earlier, you are the differentiator for the most part. So find out what is it that your listener wants to walk away with after each episode. When they invest that time in your podcast, whether it be 10 minutes, whether it be two hours, that's a commitment for them. And you should honor that by giving them something of value that they can walk away with. Because you know why? That's going to have them come back and listen again.

And there's a lot of different formatting types. You talk about in-depth interviews. *Acquired* is a great podcast. You can check that. I listened to one on the founders of NVIDIA. It's a very long-form, deep dive into the history of a company, the background about it. So super interesting. *Expert Panels* is a great one. *NASM Master Instructor Roundtable* is an excellent example.

Solo episodes are always great. I've been listening a lot to Dr. Andy Galpin's *Perform* series on the Huberman network. Really good, tons of information, very sciencey. Theme series. They're currently creating one on AthletEX news called *The Master Knowledge Series*. It's an eight-part interview specific to expert coaching knowledge that we can take into current themes of the industry like longevity or women's strength, things like that. Formats too, play around with those. And all of this kind of mixes together, right? Interview-based versus narrative storytelling versus Q&A session versus the unlimited versions of hybrid formats that are out there.

So go out and listen to a lot of different podcasts. Get a lot of different inspiration and you'll be able to bring things back to yours that are cool. It's a lot like when chefs travel across the world and go to different countries and they go to different restaurants and they look at different ingredients and pull those inspirations back to their kitchen. It's very similar to what we do in podcasting.

Another key component of differentiating is storytelling. And I think really storytelling is one of the most core things we can do as a podcaster. It's how you captivate and engage listeners. We talk a lot about sciencey-type things within the fitness, health, and wellness. And you can't just vomit data. You have to be able to tell that and wrap all that information into a way that's digestible and entertaining for the listener. And the best way to do that is through great storytelling.

And your stories-- you, dear listener-- are unique and differentiate themselves on their own. No one has the experiences that you do. And when I work with clients who want to get onto more podcasts, I always tell them you should have great stories sitting in your tool belt ready to go, a great origin story, 5 to 10 minutes of who you are, where you came from, something that imagine if you were just sitting in a coffee table and someone says, tell me about yourself, right? And you just, boom, this is my origin story. This is who I am at a high level.

And then also having several signature stories. So you could have an example of how you work with your clients and you get great results-- well, we do the x, y, and z, and we do periodized programming, and we follow this type of nutrition. OK, great. But what if you told a story about how you worked with Susie, and Susie was 50 pounds overweight, and she was busy, and she had these unique problems that she was facing, or maybe medical issues, and how you really took all of these tools that you have and this knowledge and created the storyline for how they got the results that they wanted?

That's the kind of signature story that you want. You want to have multiple of those in your back pocket for whether it's your podcast or someone else's podcast that you're guesting on. It's really important to have really great buttoned-up stories.

Authenticity-- man, I can tell you that the value of authenticity and vulnerability in building an audience is incredibly important.

And it can be a little scary at times to open up and tell people because once these podcasts are out there, they're out there, right?

So to be authentic and to be vulnerable is hard nowadays, but it truly builds a connection with your audience that is very powerful. And it allows for trust. It allows for empathy. And it's really just a winning approach to building a relationship with your listeners. So just be human is all I can say. You don't have to share your deepest, darkest secrets, but be relatable, and don't-- here's my personal belief-- don't be the one sitting at the top of the mountain saying look how great I am, look all everything I know, do what I tell you to do. People don't really like that.

They want to know that they're talking to someone who's been through some challenges. Maybe you haven't finished the book. You're just a couple chapters ahead in it. And that's a really powerful thing to have for people, and they'll tend to relate to you and trust you more. The guest experience or the guest format. Guest selection is pretty critical if you're going to have a lot of guests on your show. If you're doing an interview-based podcast, it's really important to select the right guest.

And here's the thing. It does get easier over time to get the guests you want, but making sure that you're choosing guests who align with your podcast theme, the core values, and the promise that you have is fundamental to what we're doing here. I always like to bucket my types of guests that I have on my podcast. Whether it be I want some people to make sure we're getting an even amount from health sciences, from entrepreneurship, from gym management, whatever it may be, I always want to make sure that I have three or four buckets of guests that I want to be fulfilling, and make sure we're evenly distributing across all the podcasts.

And some people like to go into having a balance between what we call audience builders, the bigger names or the bigger followings that help attract new listeners to your podcast, maybe things that are more new and noteworthy, so interesting reports that came out, or guests who are doing things that are new to your audience. And then your personal buckets. So things that maybe just interest you personally, friends of yours, colleagues of yours, or potential partners, or business development opportunities are also really interesting to have in your podcast. So that's just me. But make sure that you have if you are doing guests, that you have a nice thought-out plan of the types of guests that really associate well with your core values and your promise to your audience, and you'll do just great.

As far as acquiring the guests, there is no better way, both for time-saving and just creating the relationship off with the right start is referrals. So if you start to build friendships and relationships with other podcasters in the industry, just know that. And reach out to them, like, "Hey, I saw you had Pete or Jerry on your podcast. I would really like to interview them. Would you mind making an introduction?" That tends to work the best. If not, then you can go the old-fashioned way. Go through social media, direct messages. You can go to their website. And you can even call them on the phone if people still do that. I've heard it works.

So really important to be very focused with your guest acquisition and who you're targeting. And also swing for the fences. If there's guests that you think may be out of your reach, shoot them a message anyway. Can't hurt, I don't think. Lastly, engaging your audience is a strong differentiator. So really making sure that you are doing things outside of the podcast. Social media, obviously, is a no-brainer nowadays, creating an email list, inviting people to in-person events if that's relative what you do, or live Q&A sessions online. Incorporating the listener feedback and questions into your episode.

Give them credit. If somebody asks a question or have feedback, you can incorporate that somehow into your episodes and make sure you're giving them credit for pointing those things out. And having an open feedback loop, whether that be through email lists or some sort of method of communication. And lastly, building a community. Community can mean many things. And I think in the fitness and health industry, we have a pretty good idea of what it takes to build community. So I'm not going to sit here and lecture you on that, but overall, my interpretation of community. And it's just a group of people who share interests and values.

And I think the first step in that is really-- it sounds reductive-- but talk in terms of we, not I. When I talk about the fitness industry on my podcast, I say we, like we're all in this together. And I think that type of language goes a long way. And the rest is up to you, you know? Online communities-- you could do Facebook, you could do a Slack community, you could do in-person events that we've talked about, maybe monthly, quarterly, or just getting creative with it. So that's the lecture on "Differentiating Your Podcast." Thanks for listening. And this is Eric Malzone.

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